

EX FACTOR NCP chief Sharad Pawar, Thackeray with Congress leader Sushilkumar Shinde; (below) CM Eknath Shinde

ANI

engineering combination that we are trying to forge. Shinde's men will cut into some of our Marathi votes, but the Muslims can make up for it. The BJP could get the votes of the Hindi speakers, Gujaratis, Marwaris, Jains and upper-caste Maharashtrians."

Going against its historically adversarial relationship with the Left parties, the Thackeray faction is even willing to enlist them, the socialists and the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), to bolster the MVA's base. The alliance has also pinned its hopes on the Vanchit Bahujan Aghadi, led by former Lok Sabha MP and Babasaheb Ambedkar's grandson Prakash Ambedkar to bring in the votes of Buddhist and Hindu Dalits and the alutedar OBCs. However, a seat-sharing arrangement with Prakash has been difficult to work out, and there are doubts within the MVA on whether the alliance will come through.

The other challenge for Thackeray is to contend with the conflicting seat-sharing demands of the allies. This is the first time the Thackeray Sena is contesting election in a pre-poll alliance with erstwhile foes Congress and NCP, and seat-sharing will be a greenfield exercise, unlike that between the undivided Sena and the BJP. A former Congress minister says the MVA leadership is overwhelmed by the cacophony of too many people speaking in different voices, which affects decision-making. "Ideally, we should



MILIND SHELTE

have decided on seat-sharing and hit the ground running for the first phase of the campaign," he admits.

Though no community votes as a monolith, Marathi speakers, who form a third of Mumbai's population, are largely seen as Sena voters. While the Sena has traditionally enjoyed the support of working-class Maharashtrians, it also has pockets of support among the Gujaratis, Marwaris, Hindi speakers and the Muslims, especially those from the Konkan and western Maharashtra who speak Marathi (largely due to the grassroots connect of the party among lower and middle-income groups).

THE HURDLES

The Sena (UBT)'s biggest problem will be the new Ram temple in Ayodhya. Even hard-bitten UBT Sainiks admit some of their voters may not be averse to voting for the BJP and Prime Minister Narendra Modi, whom they see as the torchbearer of Hindutva, in the Lok Sabha election (they may still revert to being loyal to the Sena (UBT) in the assembly election later). Moreover, as the senior Sena (UBT) leader puts it, while the Congress votes could strategically shift to them, in the wake of the Ram mandir euphoria it is unlikely that the Sena's core supporters will do likewise for the Congress in a contest where a BJP candidate is in the fray. A Congress MLA fears the decades of political rivalry between the Sainiks and their counterparts from the Congress and NCP may lead to dissonance on the ground when it comes to launching a joint campaign. Shinde's biggest complaint before he split the Sena was that Thackeray had compromised the party's Hindutva ethos by allying with the "secular" Congress and NCP.

Meanwhile, Shinde Sena leader and Lok Sabha MP Rahul Shewale feels Speaker Rahul Narwekar's decision on January 10—recognising the Shinde-led faction as the real Shiv Sena—will "provide stability [to the government and the party] and induce fence-sitters to switch over". Earlier, in February 2023, the Election Commission (EC), too, had recognised Shinde's faction and granted it the name and bow-and-arrow symbol. "Most of the Shiv Sena votes are with us," he adds. "Thackeray may get the votes of the minority community, but there is an inherent contradiction there... in the Lok Sabha election, the people will vote to make Modi PM again, and hence the sympathy (for Thackeray) will be dulled. People may have these considerations during the assembly poll though...." The EC has ruled similarly in the case of the NCP, handing over the party name and symbol to deputy CM Ajit Pawar, overruling his uncle Sharad Pawar's claim.

Another source in the Shinde camp says the Ram temple and a third term for Prime Minister Modi will best any sympathy for Thackeray. "They have